

My Five Senses

How your body finds out about the world

SIGHT
eyes

HEARING
ears

SMELL
nose

TASTE
tongue

TOUCH
skin

Name: _____

Week starting: _____

Level: foundation (PreK-K). This week leads into later Biology: senses and the nervous system.

For the Grown-Up

What she will learn this week. By Friday she should be able to name the five senses, say which body part goes with each one, describe what each sense tells us, and explain that the brain is the boss that reads all the messages. She will also learn that senses help keep us safe.

Time. Five sessions of about 30 to 40 minutes. Sit next to her for the "See it first!" boxes and the activities, and let her read as much as she can herself.

How to use the "See it first!" boxes. Before reading each page, open Google Images (turn SafeSearch on), type the exact search phrase in the box, and look at the pictures together for a minute or two. Then read the explanation. Talk about what she noticed. Pictures first makes the words easier to understand.

Materials to gather. A mirror; a dim room; a rubber band; a plastic tub or bowl; a small piece of plastic wrap and some rice; cotton balls and 5 small cups; vanilla, lemon, mint leaves, cinnamon, ground coffee; a lemon wedge, a pinch of sugar, a pinch of salt, a small piece of dark chocolate; a few small pieces of apple and raw potato; a paper bag and 6 small objects (cotton ball, spoon, sandpaper, sponge, key, pine cone or similar); pencil and crayons.

SAFETY FIRST

Ask about food allergies before any tasting, and only taste food that a grown-up has given you.

Never sniff cleaning products or strong chemicals. Use only the safe kitchen smells listed.

Never shine a torch or bright light into anyone's eyes.

Keep sounds gentle. Loud noises can hurt ears.

Suggested week

Day 1	Big idea + Sight (eyes). Pupil experiment.
Day 2	Hearing (ears). Sound walk and vibration experiments.
Day 3	Smell (nose) and Taste (tongue). Smell jars and taste test.
Day 4	Touch (skin). Mystery bag. Then "Which sense?" and "Senses keep us safe."
Day 5	Research and report, label and draw page, quiz. Check with the answer key.

The Big Idea: Your Body Has Helpers

SEE IT FIRST!

Open Google Images and search: **five senses for kids**

Look at the pictures. Can you point to the body part for each sense? Which one do you use the most?

Right now, your body is finding out about the world. You can see these words. You might hear a sound in the room. You can feel the paper under your hand. How does your body know all this?

Your body has special helpers called **senses**. A sense is a way that your body finds out what is happening around you. Humans have **five main senses**:

- **Sight**: you see with your **eyes**
- **Hearing**: you hear with your **ears**
- **Smell**: you smell with your **nose**
- **Taste**: you taste with your **tongue**
- **Touch**: you feel with your **skin**

The body part that does the job for each sense is called a **sense organ**. But the sense organs cannot do everything on their own. They send messages along tiny pathways in your body called **nerves**. Nerves are a bit like wires that carry messages. The messages travel to your **brain**. Your brain is the boss. It reads all the messages and tells you what they mean: "That is a red apple." "That is a bird singing." "That stove is hot!"

FUN FACT

Your brain is working out messages from your senses all day long, even when you are asleep. That is why a loud noise or a strange smell can wake you up!

Words to Know

sense	a way your body finds out about the world
sense organ	a body part that does the job of a sense
nerve	a tiny pathway that carries messages to the brain
brain	the boss of the body that reads the messages
sight, hearing, smell, taste, touch	the five main senses

Sight: Your Eyes

SEE IT FIRST!

Open Google Images and search: **parts of the human eye diagram for kids**

Then search: **eye pupil getting bigger and smaller**

Or open kids.britannica.com and search for "eye". Find the colored part and the black dot in the middle.

You see with your **eyes**. But here is a surprise: your eyes do not make light. You can only see things because **light** bounces off them and travels into your eyes. That is why it is hard to see in a very dark room. When there is not enough light, there is nothing bouncing into your eyes!

Look at a friend's eye. In the middle is a black circle called the **pupil**. The pupil is a hole that lets light in. Around it is the colored part, called the **iris**. The iris can be brown, green, blue, or grey. The iris works like a tiny curtain. In a dark place, it opens the pupil wide to let in more light. In a bright place, it makes the pupil small so too much light does not get in.

Inside your eye, the light lands on a special spot at the back. Nerves carry the message to your brain, and your brain makes the picture. Your eyes are very soft and important, so your body protects them. **Eyelids** close to keep dust out. **Eyelashes** catch tiny bits of dirt. **Tears** wash the eye clean and keep it wet.

ACTIVITY: Watch a Pupil Change

1. Sit with a grown-up in a dim room. Look at your own eyes in a mirror. Notice how big your pupils are.
 2. Have the grown-up switch on the room light while you keep looking in the mirror. Watch your pupils get smaller!
 3. Turn the light off again and wait. Do they get bigger?
- Never shine a torch into anyone's eyes.

What did you see happen to your pupils?

Hearing: Your Ears

SEE IT FIRST!

Open Google Images and search: **parts of the ear diagram for kids**

Then search: **how sound travels into the ear for kids**

Find the part you can see on the outside of your head. What is it called?

You hear with your **ears**. Every sound is made by something **vibrating**, which means wiggling back and forth very fast. A guitar string wiggles. A drum skin wiggles. Your voice box wiggles when you talk. These wiggles push the air, and the air carries the wiggles to your ears.

The part of the ear you can see is like a funnel that catches sounds. Inside, the wiggles hit a thin skin called the **eardrum**. The eardrum wiggles like the top of a little drum. Next, tiny bones and a snail-shaped part inside your head turn the wiggles into messages. Nerves carry the messages to your brain, and your brain says, "That is a dog barking!"

FUN FACT

Loud sounds have big wiggles that can hurt the tiny parts inside your ear. Keep music and headphones low, and cover your ears near very loud noises.

ACTIVITY: Listen and Feel

Sound walk: Sit very still for two minutes with your eyes closed. Listen carefully. Then write or draw every sound you heard.

Feel the voice: Put your fingers gently on your throat and hum. What do you feel? That is your voice vibrating!

Twang: Stretch a rubber band between your fingers and pluck it. Can you see and hear it wiggle?

Sounds I heard:

Smell: Your Nose

SEE IT FIRST!

Open Google Images and search: **how does the nose smell diagram for kids**

Look for the smell nerve. Where does the message go?

You smell with your **nose**. Everything that has a smell gives off tiny, tiny bits that are too small to see. These bits float in the air. When you breathe in, the bits go up your nose to a special patch high inside. There, nerves pick up the message and send it to your brain. Your brain says, "Yum, that is bread!" or "Yuck, that is rotten!"

Your sense of smell helps you in many ways. It helps you enjoy food and flowers. It can also **warn you of danger**, like smoke from a fire or milk that has gone bad. Smell and taste are best friends. When you have a cold and your nose is blocked, food can seem to have very little taste.

FUN FACT

A dog's nose is much, much better than ours. Dogs can smell things people cannot smell at all, which is why some dogs are trained to find lost people.

ACTIVITY: Smell Jars

1. A grown-up puts a cotton ball with a little vanilla, lemon, mint, cinnamon, or coffee in each cup, and covers the cups so you cannot see inside.
2. Close your eyes. Sniff gently, one cup at a time, and guess the smell.
3. Write your guesses below. Was it easy or hard?

Cup	My guess	Real smell	Did I like it?
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

Taste: Your Tongue

SEE IT FIRST!

Open Google Images and search: **taste buds on tongue for kids**

Then search: **five basic tastes sweet sour salty bitter umami**

Look at the little bumps on the tongue. Those bumps hold your taste buds.

You taste with your **tongue**. Look at your tongue in the mirror. It is covered with tiny bumps. On the bumps are even tinier **taste buds**, and you have thousands of them! When food touches the taste buds, they send a message to your brain about what you are tasting.

Your tongue can tell five main tastes: **sweet** (like honey), **sour** (like lemon), **salty** (like chips), **bitter** (like dark chocolate), and **umami**, which means savory, like the taste of soup or cheese. Some people think that each taste happens on only one part of the tongue. That is a myth! Every part of your tongue can taste all of them.

Taste works together with smell. Try this: pinch your nose shut, close your eyes, and have a grown-up give you a small piece of apple and a small piece of raw potato. Can you tell which is which? Now let go of your nose and try again. Your nose helps your tongue a lot!

SAFETY FIRST

Check for food allergies first. Only taste what a grown-up gives you. Never taste anything you find.

ACTIVITY: Taste Test

Taste a tiny bit of each one, then color the box: lemon (sour), sugar (sweet), salt (salty), dark chocolate (bitter). Which did you like best? Which made your face scrunch up?

Food	Taste word	My face (draw it!)
Lemon		
Sugar		
Salt		
Dark chocolate		

Touch: Your Skin

SEE IT FIRST!

Open Google Images and search: **layers of skin diagram for kids**

Then search: **braille alphabet for kids** to see how some people read with their fingertips.

You feel things with your **skin**. Skin covers your whole body, and it is your body's biggest organ! Inside your skin are millions of tiny sensors. They pick up messages about what things feel like: **hot** or **cold**, **soft** or **rough**, **smooth** or **bumpy**, **light** touches and **hard** pressure. The sensors send the messages along nerves to the brain.

Some parts of your skin are extra good at feeling. Your fingertips and lips have lots of sensors, so they can feel very small details. Skin also feels **pain**. Pain is not fun, but it is very useful. It tells you to pull your hand away from something hot or sharp before you get badly hurt.

FUN FACT

Some people cannot see, so they read with their fingertips using a special code of raised dots called braille. Their sense of touch is very strong!

ACTIVITY: The Mystery Bag

1. A grown-up puts 6 objects in a paper bag (for example: a cotton ball, a spoon, sandpaper, a sponge, a key, a pine cone).
2. Put your hand in the bag WITHOUT looking. Feel one object and describe it with feeling words: soft, hard, rough, smooth, bumpy, squishy, cold.
3. Guess what it is, then pull it out to check. Write your words below.

Object I felt	Feeling words	My guess	Was I right?

Which Sense Is It?

Part 1: Match the body part to its job. Draw a line.

eyes

to smell

ears

to touch

nose

to see

tongue

to taste

skin

to hear

Part 2: Which sense do you use? Write **sight**, **hearing**, **smell**, **taste**, or **touch** next to each one.

1. Watching a rainbow

2. Listening to rain on the window

3. Smelling bread baking

4. Eating a sour lemon

5. Petting a soft cat

6. Hearing a doorbell ring

7. Feeling a hot cup of tea

8. Smelling a flower

9. Reading a book

10. Tasting honey

11. Feeling sand between your toes

12. Listening to a bird sing

Senses Keep Us Safe

SEE IT FIRST!

Open Google Images and search: **how the senses keep us safe for kids**

Look at the pictures. Which senses are being used to stay safe in each one?

Your senses are like a team of guards. They watch for danger all day long. **Eyes** spot a car coming. **Ears** hear a horn or an alarm. Your **nose** smells smoke. Your **tongue** tastes when food has gone bad. Your **skin** feels that a pan is too hot. The sense organs send the message, the nerves carry it, and the brain decides what to do, sometimes in a split second!

Think and write. Finish each sentence with a sense and a body part.

1. If I smell smoke, my _____ tells me to tell a grown-up right away.
2. If I hear a loud honk, my _____ tell me to stop and look.
3. If a cup feels very hot, my _____ tells me to pull my hand away.
4. If milk tastes sour and bad, my _____ tells me not to drink it.
5. If I see a red light, my _____ tell me to stop.

What if you lost one sense? Imagine you could not hear for one day. What would be hard? What could you use instead?

Draw and Label Yourself

Draw a picture of your face and upper body in the box. Then draw a line to each sense organ and write its name and sense. Use the word bank.

Word bank: eyes (sight), ears (hearing), nose (smell), tongue (taste), skin (touch), brain

My drawing:

My Five-Senses Hunt. Go on a safe hunt around your home or garden. Write or draw one thing for each sense.

Sense	I found...
I can SEE	
I can HEAR	
I can SMELL	
I can TASTE (ask a grown-up first)	
I can TOUCH	

Research and Report: Super-Sense Animals

Some animals have senses that are much better than ours. Your job is to become an expert on one of them, and teach your family, just like a teacher in a classroom!

Step 1: Choose one animal. Circle it, and use the search phrase to look at pictures and videos with a grown-up.

Animal	Super sense	Search phrase (Google or YouTube)
Dog	smell	how good is a dog's sense of smell for kids
Bat	hearing	how do bats use sound to find food for kids
Eagle	sight	eagle eyesight facts for kids
Cat	touch and seeing in dim light	cat whiskers facts for kids
Snake	smell (with its tongue!)	how do snakes smell with their tongue for kids

Step 2: Find 3 facts. Write or draw them here.

Step 3: Teach it! Stand up and tell your sisters and your grown-up what you learned, like you are presenting to a class. Show your drawing. Let them ask you one question. Then tick the box: ☐ I taught it!

Step 4: Write your summary. Write 3 or 4 sentences about your animal and its super sense.

Draw your super-sense animal:

My Week 1 Review

1. Fill in the blank.

I see with my _____.

I hear with my _____.

I smell with my _____.

I taste with my _____.

I feel things with my _____.

2. True or false? Circle one.

Your brain reads the messages from your senses. **TRUE / FALSE**

The pupil is the white part of your eye. **TRUE / FALSE**

Sounds are made by things vibrating. **TRUE / FALSE**

Only your fingers can feel things. **TRUE / FALSE**

Your tongue can taste sweet, sour, salty, bitter, and umami. **TRUE / FALSE**

3. Short answers.

a) What does the pupil do?

b) Why is feeling pain useful?

c) Name the boss that reads all the messages from the senses.

d) Which sense did you like testing the most this week? Why?

Answer Key and Notes (Grown-Ups)

Matching: eyes - to see; ears - to hear; nose - to smell; tongue - to taste; skin - to touch.

Which sense (Part 2): 1 sight; 2 hearing; 3 smell; 4 taste; 5 touch; 6 hearing; 7 touch; 8 smell; 9 sight; 10 taste; 11 touch; 12 hearing.

Senses keep us safe: 1 nose; 2 ears; 3 skin; 4 tongue; 5 eyes.

Quiz: Part 1: eyes, ears, nose, tongue, skin. Part 2: True, False (the pupil is the black hole in the middle), True, False (skin all over the body can feel), True. Part 3: a) the pupil lets light into the eye (and changes size for dim or bright light); b) pain warns us to move away from danger before we get badly hurt; c) the brain; d) her own opinion.

Ideas to talk about. Why can't you see in a completely dark room? (No light is bouncing into the eye.) What do a dog, a bat, and an eagle teach us about how different animals use their senses? Can a person be very good at another sense if one is missing? (Think about braille.)

Watch for. If she says the tongue map (sweet at the front, sour at the sides, and so on), gently remind her it is a myth. The pupil is a hole, not a "black circle painted on."

Next week (Week 2): Living vs Non-Living things.